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TWILIGHT OF A HERO

by QUENTIN REYNOLDS

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A correspondent who knew Sir Winston at the zenith of his greatness offers a warm reminiscence of the old lion.

On November 30, 1941, Maria Floris baked a very special birthday cake for Prime Minister Winston Churchill. To obtain the necessary butter and eggs, she must have saved her ration coupons for weeks. Good brandy was almost unobtainable in London in those days, but somehow resourceful Maria Floris (who owned a small bakery in Soho) managed to beg, borrow or, to use the word so prevalent in wartime London, "scrounge" a bottle of honorable Cognac.

It had been a fine meal. A friend from Scotland had sent Churchill some smoked salmon and, as usual, the prime minister had taken a generous helping. His enormous, baleful-eyed black cat, Nelson, was under the table waiting rather impatiently. Nelson appeared for dinner only when there was smoked salmon on the menu. The prime minister surreptitiously snatched a slice of salmon from his plate and handed it down to the cat. Nelson was not exactly a lovable pet, but he was an aggressive fighter whose ragged ears showed scars of many battles. Churchill often boasted that Nelson never bothered to fight cats, but that he never refused a contest with a dog. It was certainly true that his daughter Mary's dog, Sukie (always introduced by Mary as "my Free French poodle"), lived in terror of Nelson. So did many of Churchill's guests. When the salmon had disappeared from the prime minister's plate (most of it had gone to Nelson), the next course was served.

It was a plump, well-roasted goose that a neighbor had given him as a birthday present. When the time came to dissect it, Churchill said gaily to his wife, "You'll have to carve it, Clemmie, this goose was a friend of mine." He ate heartily and drank the fine Burgundy which complemented it so beautifully. Then he sat back well fed, hoping that Clemmie would produce some sharp Stilton cheese, which he liked much better than sweet desserts. Instead, the huge cake, white with frosting, was placed in front of him.

Trying to conceal his dismay, he cut the cake, passed slivers to his guests around the table, and then dutifully, if reluctantly, put a tiny piece into his mouth. A look of surprise was succeeded by a cherubic smile. The cake, thoroughly saturated with brandy, was very much to his taste.

Now another November 30 has come, and for the 23rd time Maria Floris (who now owns a large catering business) has baked the birthday cake. It is hardly likely that 90-year-old Sir Winston will enjoy it as much as he did the one in 1941, when he was hale and hearty, with a digestive system that cheerfully defied all laws of sensible diet. At 90, Sir Winston is a very tired and feeble old man whose alimentary problems are now of much concern to his doctors and to the seven nurses (one male, six female) who watch over him and take care of him 24 hours a day.

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